developing Sino-Pakistan relations, which made Indian officials and the public doubt Pakistani sincerity or reliability. The other was political.[56] There was little backing for any major concessions on Kashmir.[57] Nehru's reputation had suffered in India, and he faced heightened criticism in parliament. He was personally weakened—both politically and physically.[58] Komer observed that "aroused Indian nationalism [had] made Nehru far less of a free agent in foreign affairs."[59]

Even before the talks, Nehru had noted that public opinion constrained how far he could go: "India had been humiliated by [the] ChiCom attack and public opinion would not stand for further humiliation in making concessions to Pakistan"—especially, he had added, since nothing but hostility had flowed from Pakistan since the war.[60] After the talks ended, Nehru told Kennedy that further pressure to settle with Pakistan would only accentuate—rather than alleviate—India's China problem by "dampen[ing]" the public's "ardour and keenness to face the Chinese threat."[61] These were perhaps also attempts to use public opinion to limit American pressure. Nehru also resisted proposals with regard to the Kashmir valley on the grounds that it would constrain India's ability to defend itself against China in the western sector.[62] However, even officials like Harriman and British official Duncan Sandys had admitted that the Sino-Indian War made certain concessions "impossible" for the Indian prime minister, including a plebiscite and the transfer of the Kashmir valley "as such" to Pakistan.[63]

The related American tactic of linking military aid and the India-Pakistan talks had a long-lasting impact on not just public opinion but also policy opinion. Nehru claimed that the linkage increased public pressure on him not to make concessions on Kashmir for aid.[64] Earlier, Indian ambassador to the US B. K. Nehru had predicted that it would also make a settlement harder by making Pakistan more intransigent.[65] Perhaps most significantly, in India linkage led to resentment of the US and reinforced the sense that dependence—particularly on one major actor—came with significant downsides. Indians saw the Harriman-Sandys mission that had arrived just after the war as, at best, persuading or, at worst, pressuring Nehru to accept talks. Those inclined toward the latter view saw the dialogue with Pakistan as the "political price" Delhi had to pay to continue